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» CHIRAG SHETTY, 26 SATWIKSAIRAJ REDDY, 23
BADMINTON
MEN'S DOUBLES, MEN'S TEAM

Shuttlers Chirag Shetty and Satwiksairaj Reddy or SatChi, as they are popularly known among their fans, possess a zeal and flair that once made Leander Paes and Mahesh Bhupathi a.k.a. the Indian Express a duo to root for. Their pairing is proof how yin and yang relationships click.

Shetty hails from Mumbai and likes to sample international cuisine; Reddy is from Amalapuram in Andhra Pradesh and is the sort to seek out Indian restaurants even while playing abroad. If Shetty takes off his shirt after a win, Reddy would rather show off his dance moves. Shetty is the more vocal of the two on court, exhibiting a Virat Kohli-like winner's instinct. "When I am aggressive, I feel a lot more at peace on the court and confident in my stroke quality and perform a whole lot better," says Shetty. Reddy, on the other hand, likes to be "cool and calm". "I don't take too much to my head." It's these contrasting traits that make them one of the most formidable pairs in men's badminton.

Shetty and Reddy have been playing together for seven years, but 2023 is easily their breakthrough year. They already have four titles under their belt, including the Indonesian Open, the badminton equivalent of a grand slam, in addition to being the Asian Champions. The scintillating form has seen them catapult to #2 in world rankings, the highest for an Indian pair—men's or women's. If they just maintain it in Hangzhou, they are bound to put the country on the podium for the first time since the 1982 Asian Games when India won a medal in men's doubles (bronze). Its last men's medal came in 1986 in the team event. History could repeat itself in Hangzhou.

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The 2023 men's contingent is a strong contender for the team event, especially since it features the same players that won the Thomas Cup last year in what was a euphoric moment for India. "The whole team started playing better in individual events too," says Shetty about the impact of being men's team world champions. "It taught us how to play better in crucial stages, it gave us confidence."

A key reason why Shetty and Reddy have been winning a lot more is the entry of Mathias Boe, the doubles coach and an Olympic medalist in men's doubles. Boe has brought in much-needed discipline to their routine. "He is hard [on us], you don't see that part," says Reddy with a boyish grin. "He is always pushing us 200 per cent in practice. His professionalism has rubbed off on both of us. We now take care of our bodies and have proper rest." Adds Shetty, "He has helped us plan our schedule and what we want to achieve." Their aim is not just to win a medal at the Asian Games but also the All England Championships, the world title (they have a bronze) and to become the first Indian male shuttlers to win an Olympic medal.

With their newfound fame, the duo has their work cut out in Hangzhou where the field will feature the world's best in Korean, Chinese, Indonesian, Malaysian and Japanese pairs. SatChi will be giving it their best shot. **-SS**